



Social media as public opinion: How journalists use social media to represent public opinion

Journalism
2019, Vol. 20(8) 1070–1086
© The Author(s) 2019
Article reuse guidelines:
sagepub.com/journals-permissions
DOI: 10.1177/1464884919845458
journals.sagepub.com/home/jou



Shannon C McGregor

The University of Utah, USA

Abstract

Public opinion, as necessary a concept it is to the underpinnings of democracy, is a socially constructed representation of the public that is forged by the methods and data from which it is derived, as well as how it is understood by those tasked with evaluating and utilizing it. I examine how social media manifests as public opinion in the news and how these practices shape journalistic routines. I draw from a content analysis of news stories about the 2016 US election, as well as interviews with journalists, to shed light on evolving practices that inform the use of social media to represent public opinion. I find that despite social media users not reflecting the electorate, the press reported online sentiments and trends as a form of public opinion that services the horserace narrative and complements survey polling and vox populi quotes. These practices are woven into professional routines – journalists looked to social media to reflect public opinion, especially in the wake of media events like debates. Journalists worried about an overreliance on social media to inform coverage, especially Dataminr alerts and journalists' own highly curated Twitter feeds. Hybrid flows of information between journalists, campaigns, and social media companies inform conceptions of public opinion.

Keywords

Campaign coverage, journalistic routines, political communication, public opinion, social media, vox populi

Corresponding author:

Shannon C McGregor, The University of Utah, Department of Communication, 255 Central Campus Drive, Salt Lake City, UT, 84112 USA.

Email: shannon.c.mcgregor@gmail.com

Social public opinion in campaign news

If public opinion is ‘a contested and malleable concept’ (Herbst, 1998: 2), then understanding the ways in which it is constructed, particularly by elites like journalists who reflect our opinion(s) back to us via news coverage, is of utmost importance for the practice of democracy. And yet, the meaning of public opinion is contingent: ‘The social climate, technological milieu, and communication environment in any democratic state together determine the way we think about public opinion and the ways we try to measure it’ (Herbst, 1998: 1). The rise of social media is a significant aspect of today’s hybrid media system (Chadwick, 2013), which focuses on the interactions between political actors, the media, and the public. These shifting dynamics, and the communication technologies that enable and support them, necessarily reorder the social, technical, and communication contingencies upon which public opinion is constructed. If survey methods helped to form a mass public, what type of public do social media and their metrics form?

As I document here, social media and their metrics provide an emerging means of measuring and representing the public. Social media do not stand to replace surveys as a means to measure public opinion, but rather provide a distinct representation of the public. In fact, this representation of public opinion through social media is flawed in different ways than surveys are limited. Yet, social media as a form of public opinion is impossible to ignore. Journalists draw on social media in various ways in the course of their reporting on political contests, from documenting public reaction to media events to evaluating the performances of candidates.

For so long, polling has dominated these understandings of public opinion, but the entrance of social media – and its data – to the political scene has disrupted these practices. In documenting to what extent, and how, journalists turn to social media data to understand the public, I chart the important implications for the practices of journalism, as well as for the study of public opinion itself.

Representations of public opinion

As of late, those tasked with representing public opinion – political actors and the news media (as well as academics) – have primarily utilized survey polls to represent a mass public opinion. But the necessarily mediated process of crafting citizens’ actual opinions into a consumable product is of course malleable and selective. Public opinion, as necessary a concept it is to the underpinnings of democracy, is a socially constructed representation of the public that is forged by the methods and data from which it is derived, as well as how it is understood by those tasked with evaluating and utilizing it.

Sarah Igo’s (2007) *The Averaged American* charts the development of contemporary representations of public opinion via survey polling. She argues that polling is a distinct practice that represents the public in particular ways that was legitimated in part due to a set of political claims in relation to democracy. Beginning in the 1940s, George Gallup and Elmo Roper dismissed straw polls, ushering what we now see as standards in public opinion polling: generating representative samples and surveying individuals about their opinions, including on candidates running for office (Gallup and Rae, 1940; Igo, 2007).

These epistemological underpinnings of polling have shaped normative assumptions about public opinion more broadly, but have not gone without criticism. As early as 1948, the sociologist Herbert Blumer (1948) argued that survey methods could not possibly assess the nature of actual public attitudes, as they ignore the social and indeed the *public* aspects of public opinion. Polling purports that opinion is individualized, yet illustrative of a public. In the inaugural issue of *Public Opinion Quarterly*, Allport (1937) lays out the vision of a public opinion that is ‘defined as the number of people holding a certain opinion, and the people holding that opinion would be identified as belonging to the public’ (p. 9). As Peters (1995) points out, this is a circular (and self-reinforcing) vision of public opinion that creates at times rather arbitrary groupings of individuals to form a public, who may not see themselves as belonging to a ‘public’ manufactured by associations found in survey data. Furthermore, as Blumer (1948) and others have noted (see also, Entman and Herbst, 2001; Fishkin, 2006), surveys reveal individual not social opinion, obfuscating the societal and collective components of public opinion. Representativeness is a normative value in survey research, beyond its statistical necessity methodologically. Representativeness allows a small group of individuals to voice an ‘empirical truth’ (Peters, 1995: 19), which early advocates of polling saw as a way to not only hold elected officials accountable, but also as a correction to loud, but small (and unrepresentative) groups in society. As Peters (1995) continues, ‘Unrepresentative samples and unrepresentative politics, then, are the respective fears that keep scholars treating the public as an aggregate of dispersed individuals; to do so otherwise has long seemed either unscientific or undemocratic’ (p. 19). But claims that mass public opinion represents the public (e.g. Zaller, 1992) have been called into question by critics who assert that interactions between groups within the public mold public opinion (e.g. Blumer, 1948; Fishkin, 2006). Critics note that using surveys to measure a mass public fails to account for the hierarchical nature of society and the role of elites in opinion formation, in which various groups and individuals wield influence (Blumer, 1948; Herbst, 1998). Finally, opinion polling rests on the implicit assumption that individuals hold private opinions, which may not only be different from those they express publicly, but hold some higher value in their very private-ness. This strips publicness from public opinion, by measuring it in a private (and anonymous) setting, putting survey-based public opinion at odds with classic aspects of democracy such as participation and discussion (or its highest ideal, deliberation) (e.g. Berelson, 1952; Habermas, 1989). In sum, surveys rest on an implicit model in which opinion is an individuated, measurable, and private phenomenon that pollsters can access (see Graber, 2006) and aggregate to represent the public as a whole – to paint a picture of the average American (Igo, 2007). But critiques of this paradigm, which arose nearly simultaneously with polling’s dominance in measuring public opinion, have not made significant dents in the perceived legitimacy of surveys to gauge public opinion.

Polling remains the paradigmatic representation of public opinion, despite evidence of a precipitously declining response rate as well as reliability problems related to cell phone use and Internet polling. Against this backdrop of a crisis in polling methodology and questions about accuracy (AAPOR, 2013; Pew Research Center, 2012; Zukin, 2015, but see Jennings and Wlezien, 2018), new ways of representing public opinion have emerged. Social media platforms’ sharp uptake by the public (nearly 70% of the US

public is on Facebook; Pew Research Center, 2016) coupled with the availability of trace behavioral data available about users (Jungherr, 2015) has led to consideration of social media as an emergent way to measure public attitudes. Studies attempting to predict election outcomes based on social media data have mostly failed (Jungherr, 2015; Schober et al., 2016). To date, little attention has been paid to the ways in which social media are already deployed as representations of public opinion. I suggest that these debates are too narrow, obfuscating a broader question: *What role do social media play in how elites understand and represent public opinion?*

Social media as public opinion

Measurable social media metrics subvert some of the underlying methodological assumptions of surveys, as outlined above. There is no representative sampling, for instance; platforms, as well as practitioners who use sentiment, topic, content, or other computational analyses to study communication on them, use the sum total of available posts, tweets, or likes to draw conclusions about aggregate public opinion. For some, these deviations from survey assumptions may problematize social media data for understanding public opinion. On the other hand, using social media data to understand the public may address some lingering criticisms of surveys – specifically that surveys do not capture the conversational or hierarchical nature of public opinion formation or that the operationalization of survey questions too narrowly defines public opinion.

I suggest that social media allow for a more *public*, *relational*, and *temporally sensitive* representation of public opinion. Political opinions expressed on social media are inherently *public* and *relational* in that they are expressed publicly to or for an audience. Given their conversational nature, social media represent a public and collective arena in which public opinion manifests, similar to public meetings or citizen groups (Anstead and O’Loughlin, 2015). As a criticism of the modern public opinion survey, Blumer (1948) argued that individuals form opinions through social interactions, which are not captured via private surveys of individuals. If surveys measure anonymized attitudes expressed in isolation, then social media data offer a means to recapture the relationality of public opinion. Quantifiable metrics such as likes and replies are measures of interactions between individuals, while posts like tweets or comments can be understood contextually based on an individual’s perceived audiences. Furthermore, opinions expressed on social media expand the *temporal* boundaries of socially constructed public opinion. Both surveys and social media analysis offer a snapshot of attitudes in any given moment, but social media offer more temporal sensitivity in gauging public sentiment because of their ability to capture public expression and reaction to political events as they unfold, literally minute by minute. This increased temporal sensitivity also allows further specificity in assessing particular publics, such as audiences for televised political events (Gil de Zúñiga et al., 2015; Vaccari et al., 2015).

My aim here is to understand how journalists use social media to *construct* public opinion, explicitly situating social media within the ontology of public opinion. As Igo (2007) convincingly argues, modern polling techniques became dominant at least in part because their uptake by journalists legitimized them in the eyes of the public. To the extent that journalists use social media to represent and understand public opinion, this may have a legitimizing force on an emergent source of data in politics.

Journalism and public opinion

Journalists, and by extension the news media, have played an important role in shaping polling data into public opinion (Herbst, 1998; Igo, 2007). As polling relied in part on journalists for legitimization and dissemination, so too did journalism come to rely on polling. News industry economics and journalistic norms both help explain the news media's increasing use of opinion polls in reporting. As newsrooms continue to shrink due to economic challenges, stories utilizing polls offer an easy (and compelling) storyline to orient political or breaking news (Goidel, 2011), require minimal editing or interpretation (Rosenstiel, 2005), fit with news values like timeliness and conflict (Shoemaker and Reese, 2013), and appeal to audiences (Iyengar et al., 2004). Furthermore, Dunaway (2011) shows that news organizations facing steep competition and in need of profits are more likely to rely on poll-centered horserace stories at the expense of more substantive stories, such as those focused on issues. Others have posited that political theories of news production may explain journalists' reliance on polls in reporting. In 'negotiating newsworthiness', political journalists have been shown to rely heavily on their relationship with officials as part of their work routine (Bennett, 1990; Lawrence, 2000). In part, as a reaction against politicians' attempts to stage events and control narratives, public opinion polls present a platform for political journalists to interpret the current political-electoral situation for their readers, using their 'journalistic voice' and their expertise reporting on public affairs to explain the shifts in citizens' views (Zaller, 1998). Finally, reliance on polling may be attributed to 'scientific journalism'. Public opinion polls – presented in the news with the support of hard figures and obtained using presumably scientific methods – provide a veneer of objectivity and accuracy to journalists' interpretation of politics (Lavrakas and Traugott, 2000).

Social media data, especially in quantified form, stand to provide journalists with many of the same tools as has polling. Social media data and metrics offer journalists an easy storyline against which to orient political news. To the extent that data are provided by social media firms for news outlets (Kreiss and McGregor, 2017), their presentation requires little editing. By the nature of their quantification, social media data also give journalists a near-instantaneous metric by which to measure political winners and losers, meeting news values like timeliness and conflict, while working in favor of horserace-style coverage. Social media data can also be used by journalists to push back against politicians' attempts to control political narratives.

For journalists, social media data may be more accessible than polls. Reporters can access what researchers at social media companies produce for them around media events: Facebook and Twitter have entire teams dedicated to doing so (Kreiss and McGregor, 2017). Many newsrooms also have access to analytics tools like Facebook's Signal¹ and Dataminr.² In contrast to polling, social media provide journalists a glimpse at the continuously unfolding phenomenon of opinion online, which they can draw from for their reporting. Journalists can also access individual public posts on social media, which can be used in service of reporting. Political journalists congregate on Twitter (Lawrence, Molyneux, Coddington, and Holton, 2014), which shapes their news judgment (McGregor and Molyneux, 2018), providing journalists ready access to a multitude of public reactions to media events. Journalists have long featured so-called 'person on

the street' interviews to represent vox populi. In more recent years, journalists have also turned to social media to gather vox populi quotes as qualitative measures of public opinion (Anstead and O'Loughlin, 2015; Lukito and Wells, 2018).

In his detailed typology of the use of polls in election coverage, Toff (2016) identified two categories of public opinion representations that inform this study. First, 'partisan scorekeeping' is similar to the well-documented trend of horserace coverage, but Toff (2016) more broadly defined these stories as focused on 'tracking the political fortunes of elected officials and the parties, using polls to make assertions about who is up or down in the political "score"' (p. 120). The second category Toff (2016) develops is 'public opinion storytelling' – an aspect of contextual journalism, wherein journalists used polling data to move 'beyond' election results to uncover people's attitudes about certain issues.

Social media offer a window into people's attitudes about candidates, parties, and even issues through their own comments (as qualitative representations), while also providing quantifiable data via metrics. Combining an interest in the form as well as the function of social media as representations of public opinion in the press, I ask:

RQ1: To what extent, and how, do journalists use social media to engage in *partisan scorekeeping* in election reporting?

RQ2: To what extent, and how, do journalists use social media to engage in *public opinion storytelling* in election reporting?

Methods

I answer these research questions through a qualitative textual analysis of interviews with journalists, which was guided by an exploratory content analysis of 2016 US election coverage.

News media data

These data stem from news media coverage of the 2016 US election in order to assess how social media were used to represent public opinion. I began by accessing a database of stories related to the election, as gathered by Media Cloud³ In order to focus the data on my specific inquiry, as well as to make possible hand-coding, I narrowed the data along three lines: date, news media sources, and keywords.

I queried the MediaCloud election database⁴ for stories that were published between 1 April 2015, and 8 November 2016 (Election Day). Next, I filtered by source type.⁵ Although the MediaCloud database contains stories from 70,166 media sources, I searched within these for sources identified by the Pew Research Center in its State of the News Media 2016 (Mitchell et al., 2016) report.⁶ I searched for cable news (3 sources), digital-native publishers (40 sources), magazines (14 sources), network TV (3 sources), newspapers (49 sources), and public broadcasting (2 sources). In sum, my data stem from 111 news outlets (see Appendix A for a complete list). Finally, I searched for keywords within the data to narrow in on the data outcroppings (Luker, 2008) in which I

was interested – the use of social media to represent public opinion. Identifying the final keyword query was an iterative process, but I eventually settled on searching for the candidate's names, election keywords, social media sites, and other keywords identified by reading stories throughout the process. The final keywords I searched were:

((florina OR (scott and walker) OR (ben and carson) OR trump OR (cruz AND -victor) OR kasich OR rubio OR (jeb and bush) OR clinton OR sanders OR candidate OR election OR presidential) and (((comment OR reply OR 'the internet' OR 'twitterverse' OR retweet OR like OR follower OR favorite OR share OR interactions OR 'top tweet' OR 'top social moment' OR 'most-liked' OR 'most-mentioned' OR trending OR conversation OR users) AND (Twitter OR Facebook OR Snapchat OR Instagram)))

The final query yielded 2299 stories.

Content analysis. A trained coder and I examined a random sample ($n = 150$) of the initial 2299 stories returned by my query, performing an initial reading of the stories to assess whether they represented my phenomenon of interest: social media or its metrics used to represent public opinion. Stories were coded as to whether or not they took up social media, posts, or metrics, in service of public opinion. For example, a story featuring public reaction, via individual tweets, to Donald Trump's debate performance were coded 1, and was examined further to answer my research questions. On the other hand, stories that focused on Trump's use of Twitter (without featuring reaction from the public) also sometimes appeared in my data – but these stories were coded 0, and were not examined further. We reached 92 percent agreement, with a Krippendorff alpha of .848.⁷ This coding process yielded 770 stories of interest for further coding, after removing duplicates. From this, I drew a 50 percent random sample of 385 stories, upon which the following analyses are based. The analysis of this sample provides a descriptive basis for readers to further understand my interviews with journalists, which were conducted after the content analysis.

In the end, the stories I examined further make up what Luker (2008) calls 'data outcroppings', where my concept of interest was most apparent. I selected these data purposively, knowing that my findings are not statistically representative, relying instead on logical generalizability (Luker, 2008). I have no reason to think that the news media data I analyzed were different from other news media reports in systematic ways that might affect my findings about the use of social media to represent public opinion.

In order to answer RQ1, stories that used social media or their metrics in service of positioning a candidate (or party) in relation to others, be it winning or losing, rising or falling, ahead or behind, were coded as *partisan scorekeeping*. With a trained coder, we reached 95 percent agreement on this category, with a Krippendorff's alpha of .89. In order to answer RQ2, stories that used social media or its metrics to explain or make sense of public attitudes toward a particular issue were coded as *public opinion storytelling*. In this category, we reached 97 percent agreement, with a Krippendorff's alpha of .94.

To further answer both research questions and examine how journalists used social media in their reporting, or what form the dual functions coded for above took, stories were also coded as to whether or not they took up individual post(s) as *qualitative*

representations of public opinion (e.g. quoting or inserting a single social media post, or collection of posts). Along with a trained coder, we reached 100 percent agreement on this category, with a Krippendorff's alpha of 1. Stories were also coded for whether or not they present *quantitative* social media counts or metrics to represent the public (e.g. number of followers, likes, comments, favorites, etc.; number of posts about a given topic, issue; number of posts with a particular sentiment or favorability). With this category, we reached 90 percent agreement, with a Krippendorff's alpha of .80.

Interview analysis. The content analysis described above offers a chance to detail the ways in which journalists used social media to represent public opinion while reporting on the 2016 US election. I also wanted to understand how this relatively new data shaped the production of news. Hearing from journalists, in their own words, served the critical function of bringing into focus the role that social media played in their production of news about public opinion during the course the 2016 campaign.

Toward this end, I interviewed journalists whose bylines appeared in my news media data set. I sought specifically to interview journalists who used social media data to represent public opinion. I created a list of all the authors in my data set, along with the news outlets for which they worked. I began by contacting journalists whose bylines appeared often in my data, while also taking care to represent the various types of news media in my data. At the end of each interview, if it had not already come up, I asked if there were other people with whom that reporter thought I should speak. Because of this, additional subjects were contacted and added throughout the data collection period.

In June and July of 2017, I interviewed 18 journalists on the role of social media data in their reporting about the 2016 US presidential campaign. These individuals are Andrew Kahn, assistant interactives editor for *Slate*; Brian Lisi, a reporter for *New York Daily News*; David Jackson, a White House correspondent for *USA Today*; David Mack, a reporter and weekend editor for *Buzzfeed*; Derek Willis, a news applications developer for *ProPublica*; Eliza Collins, a congressional reporter for *USA Today*; Evan McMurray, a social media editor for ABC News; Greg Krieg, a politics reporter for CNN; Heather Leighton, a digital producer for the *Houston Chronicle*; James Hohmann, a national political correspondent for *The Washington Post*; Jason Silverstein, a national politics reporter for the *New York Daily News*; Josh Voorhees, a senior writer for *Slate*; Matt Conlen, a computational journalist for *FiveThirtyEight*; Mitch Thorson, an interactives graphics editor for *USA Today*; Paul Singer, a Washington correspondent for *USA Today*; Philip Bump, a national correspondent for *The Washington Post*; Rueben Fischer-Baum, a visual journalist for *FiveThirtyEight*; and YouYou Zhou, an interactive producer for *The Associated Press*. All of these interviews were conducted on the record, although participants could declare any statement not for attribution (directly quoted but anonymously sourced), on background (not directly quoted), or off the record (not reported in any way) at their discretion. On average, the interviews lasted about 45 minutes.

I began these semi-structured interviews with journalists by asking them about their role during the 2016 campaign. I asked them what they relied on to understand public attitudes throughout the campaign, and what role, specifically, social media played. I asked them about how they gathered social media data about public opinion and for what purpose these social media data were used in reporting. In particular, these questions

were informed by the previously described content analysis. Finally, I asked these journalists to reflect on the potential utilities, and downsides, of using social media to represent public opinion.

In reading and analyzing my interviews with journalists, I followed an integrated approach – bridging inductive categories emerging from a textual analysis while integrating existing literature on theories of public opinion and the press (Luker, 2008). I sought to determine specific patterns of reporting on, or with, social media data in both qualitative and quantitative ways. Furthermore, I aimed to understand how journalists viewed social media data's utility for reporting on public opinion about candidates, parties (partisan scorekeeping), and issues (public opinion storytelling).

‘The Internet’ speaks: Representing the public through social media and metrics in campaign reporting

I examined to what extent, and how, journalists use social media data to represent public opinion in their reporting. In analyzing news stories about the 2016 US presidential election and capturing in their own words the routines and practices of journalists who take up the essential task of communicating public opinion to the public, I reveal these emerging dynamics with the aim of informing and improving future public opinion research and journalism.

My first research question looks to the use of social media to engage in *partisan scorekeeping*. I first present results from the content analysis, followed by an extended look at the practice through the experiences of journalists who engaged in it.

News stories were coded as to whether or not social media were being used in service of partisan scorekeeping, wherein social media metrics – or individual posts – were used to show public evaluations of a certain candidate or party or their campaign strategies. A majority of the stories using social media to represent public opinion did so in this style – 74.8 percent. For example, a story from *The Washington Post*⁸ relied on social media to substantiate its claim in the headline ‘Anger won and Rubio lost last night’s debate’.

More than half of election stories utilizing social media to engage in partisan scorekeeping employed quantitative representations (62.8%). For example, a story on MSNBC.com⁹ compared Facebook engagement numbers from GOP candidate Rick Santorum’s campaign launch posts to that of a post by Ted Cruz about the mobile game Candy Crush, under the headline ‘Cruz’s gamer post got more traction than Santorum’s big announcement’.

Half of the stories that used social media in service of partisan scorekeeping employed qualitative representations of public opinion (50%). Another story on MSNBC.com featured individual Twitter posts using the hashtag #HillarySoQualified from Clinton supporters in response to Bernie Sander’s comment that Hillary Clinton was not qualified to be President. Social media posts provided not only another way to quote people, but also, like polls, contributed to the norm of objectivity while still allowing journalists their ‘interpretive voice’. In using social media posts from the public within their stories, journalists themselves did not have to criticize any candidate directly. In my interviews, many journalists spoke of the need for having a ‘theory’ for the story – for the reason these particular social media posts were embedded in a news piece. In this way, social

media posts provided easy evidence for journalists' 'meta-narratives' about a candidate: Trump as a joke, Sanders with grassroots support.

As my interviews also reveal, journalists routinely saw social media data as a way to quantitatively indicate the popularity of candidates. Andrew Kahn, of *Slate*, worked on a feature that was updated weekly throughout the election, Twitter Power Rankings, which displayed the extent to which tweets from candidates were liked and retweeted. As he told me:

The main thing that I wanted to convey with the visualization was how big the pie was, and how big each person's slice of the pie was. I wanted to convey as clearly as possible how much room the most popular Twitter candidates were taking up, and how much room the most popular tweets from those candidates were taking up.

Journalists also relied on both quantitative and qualitative representations of social media to convey public attitudes about candidate performance at key media events, like the nominating conventions and debates. Social media metrics were often used to convey who 'won' a particular debate. The journalists I spoke to acknowledged the power of social media – and the particular representation of public opinion that they saw on it – to shape news coverage and evaluations of political performances and fortunes. As James Hohmann, of *The Washington Post* noted:

And because everyone's talking on social media and there's this conversation on social media, it speeds up what used to take like three days. Sort of like [you] have some definitiveness about who had won or lost the debate or what the key moment had been. ... Like, the next morning, I would be able to say definitively, 'Bernie Sanders won the debate because of these online mentions and the focus was on this and the focus'. ... you know, like it's bad for Hillary Clinton for these three reasons and then I could aggregate, you know. Here are 30 really good tweets and use the tweets to bolster the argument.

While partisan scorekeeping stories featuring individual social media posts were curated by journalists (often aided by Dataminr, which several journalists described to me as a de facto assignment editor), social media firms played a more active role in communicating metrics to journalists. 'Twitter, Facebook, Google, are all pretty deliberate about trying to get mentioned in things, so during the debates for example, each of those platforms would send notes. 'Here's what people are searching for. Here's what people are tweeting about', et cetera', said Philip Bump, of *The Washington Post*. This echoed what nearly every journalist relayed to me about how social media firms actively worked to get their data into public opinion reporting about the election. As Jason Silverstein, of the *NY Daily News*, noted:

I just know that from a reporter standpoint ... the way that we were determining what are we going to break out, what are we going to write about off of this debate was largely looking at what kind of stories had become big on Google, what kinds of things had started trending on Facebook, [and] on Twitter, what things were getting the biggest reaction.

Journalists adopted social media in their reporting at least in part because these companies promoted and directly contacted reporters to share candidate and media-event metrics, particularly after debates. This shared data shaped coverage, as evidenced in the content analysis as well as interviews with journalists.

My second research question examines journalists' use of social media to portray public opinion about issues during their election coverage. Social media was not often used in stories to represent public opinion on issues – only 26 percent of stories used social media that way. A story on Salon.com¹⁰ used social media to portray issue-focused public sentiment on Clinton under the headline '#WhichHillary? Twitter trend calls out Clinton for hypocrisy on racism, Wall Street and war: After a Black Lives Matter activist disrupted a fundraiser, critics on Twitter condemned Clinton's double standards'.

As my analysis shows, social media did not play a substantial role in informing deeper issue-focused coverage during the 2016 election – but there were distinct differences in the way journalists did so along qualitative versus quantitative lines. A little more than half (55%) of the stories using social media to represent public opinion on issues did so qualitatively. Journalists wrote stories featuring collections of individual social media posts to convey public attention to certain issues throughout the campaign, notably the Dakota Pipeline (#noDAPL) and racial discrimination (#BlackLivesMatter). Many of these stories focused solely on a trending hashtag.

Not all journalists were positive about the use of social media as a source for vox populi quotes. And yet, journalists who engaged in this practice themselves saw a greater chance of misuse in the hands of other journalists – a sort of third-person (journalist) effect.¹¹ In this case, the journalists I spoke with did not express concerns about inferring public opinion from their own potentially narrow Twitter feeds, but worried about that impact on other journalists. For example, many journalists noted that they mostly followed other journalists and political players in Washington, D.C., yet they still used their own Twitter feeds to 'take the pulse' of public opinion.

Especially for purposes of drawing qualitative understandings of public opinion, journalists favored Twitter predominantly over other social media sites. In reflecting on the apparent favoritism toward Twitter, particularly for vox populi quotes, David Mack, of *Buzzfeed*, said, 'I think there's a few reasons why people look to Twitter, and as I said it's because it's probably the place where journalists are the most comfortable and but also because of the quantity of content that comes through there as well'.

Reporting on issues via social media in quantitative terms involves gaining access to large troves of data from these platforms, as well as the ability to computationally parse data. Perhaps because of this, quantitative representations of social media attention to issues stemmed mostly from the technology firms themselves. Of stories that did use social media to portray deeper, issue-focused public opinion, a majority (66%) featured quantitative measures of public opinion.

ABC News partnered with Facebook to live-stream the general election debates. As part of this partnership, ABC News' reporting team got metrics on the debates from Facebook shortly before they were publicly released. As Evan McMurray, political social media reporter for ABC News during the election, recounted:

We used [social media metrics] a lot in broadcasting, as kind of a bump. You know, coming in from a commercial we would throw up a graphic and say, 'We're an hour into night three of the convention. Here are the big topics so far on Facebook...' I would tweet them out as soon as I got them, usually from Twitter and Facebook, and I found they got a lot of engagement.

Parsing public attention or interest to issues from social media requires more work than simple candidate-name searches. Journalists relied on, and reported on, analysis of issues in social media conversations done by the social media firms themselves. Many journalists noted what a 'blunt tool' social media metrics were for understanding candidate favorability, particularly with the unreliability of sentiment analysis. Building on this, some journalists saw promise in future uses of social media to understand what issues motivate the public. 'Social media's information around issues can be much more illuminating, because I don't care as much about whether you're in favor of Hillary Clinton or Donald Trump', said Paul Singer, of *USA Today*. 'I'm much more interested to know why, and what's motivating you'.

Discussion

I began this study shortly after the 2016 US presidential election, convinced of the importance of social media in today's hybrid media system, notably for the ways in which the public participates in their own representation of the slippery concept of public opinion. The concept of public opinion, through which individuals can be heard by political elites, and each other, is vital to democracy. But public opinion is socially constructed, forged by the methods and data from which it manifests, as well as how it is understood by political actors tasked with evaluating and representing it. As social media data is used by elites to understand and represent public opinion, the concept itself transforms. If survey methods formed a mass public, my findings suggest we are now in the early stages of a social public.

In detailing how, and why, journalists use social media data in their political reporting, I show how routinized processes, like newsroom norms and editorial practices, shape news content. Editors encouraged journalists to include individual social media posts in post-debate coverage. Journalists took the pulse of public opinion from their own elite-dominated Twitter feeds, and the use of Dataminr alerts to drive coverage was ubiquitous. These practices indicate emergent norms around the use of social media data in public opinion reporting. Social media posts and quantified metrics are interpreted by journalists as measures of public opinion, which impact coverage of candidate qualities and qualifications and assessments of a campaign's fortunes and competitiveness – both of which shape public attitudes and behaviors, including voting. Journalists give force and form to slippery concepts like 'momentum' in part by how they interpret, and make use of, these emergent forms of public opinion (see also Karpf, 2016).

Social media as an emergent representation of public opinion brings the public closer to politics and political actors, sometimes in remarkably visible ways – journalists reported social media posts as vox populi opinions. And yet, this proximity to politics may not result in more power for the public in political processes – for all of this is mediated by social media firms themselves. In fact, social media companies like Facebook and Twitter have gained immense power in part because they are purveyors of this

emergent public opinion. Journalists' use of social media to represent public opinion grants legitimacy to social media firms, as these companies create and steer flows of information to the press.

These hybrid flows shape routines. There has been considerable research showing the impact of Twitter on the working routines of journalists (Armstrong and Gao, 2010; Broersma and Graham, 2016; Lawrence et al., 2014; Lasorsa et al., 2012). On Twitter, journalists come to make sense of news at least in part because they tend to engage primarily with other journalists (Molyneux and Mourão, 2017), where they construct news narratives (Mourão, 2015). A recent experiment found that the routinization of Twitter into news production shapes news judgment (McGregor and Molyneux, 2018). The world journalists encounter via their own Twitter feeds is relatively enclosed and insular, yet my research suggests this informs coverage of public opinion.

Social media can bring public, collective, and societal components to representations of public opinion – offering a chance to address critiques of the polling paradigm as old as the practice itself (Blumer, 1948; Entman and Herbst, 2001; Fishkin, 2006; Graber, 2006; Habermas, 1989; Herbst, 1993; Herbst, 1998; Peters, 1995). But the use of social media to understand and represent public opinion may also give voice to unrepresentative, manipulable, loud, and likely polarized opinions. By counting and cherry picking, and not taking up analysis that could reveal the dynamics of opinion formation on social media, journalists open the door to expanded conceptions of public opinion, but ultimately give it short shrift.

Public opinion understood through surveys is private, individual, representative, and measurable. On the other hand, public opinion understood through social media is public, relational, hierarchical, and measurable. These two conceptions of public opinion are joined only by their embrace of rationality, but as of yet, measures that capture (and also mitigate) the unique aspects of opinion formation that social media can bring to our understanding of public opinion have not been embraced by journalists. Public opinion is of course contextual to any particular historical moment. In this moment, the rhetorical construction of public opinion finds expanding strength in social media, given that it can be represented easily (*vox pop*) and underpinned with quantitative data (metrics), wherein the quantifiability and rationality lend social-science credibility to it.

This study aims to provide a preliminary description of an emergent phenomenon – journalists' use of social media to understand, report on, and represent public opinion in the news. The exploratory content analysis was designed to understand how social media appeared as representations of public opinion in news about the 2016 US presidential election, but it cannot tell us how prevalent this practice was across all election news. Future work in this area could compare the prevalence of polling-based and social media-based reporting on public opinion. The prominence of the outlets engaged in this practice suggests it was not insignificant, and my interviews with journalists reveal these practices are already deeply woven into reporting routines. Of course, the categories I examined are far from exhaustive. My future work in this area inductively seeks and develops additional categories to represent the ways in which journalists use social media to represent public opinion.

From a normative perspective, the use of social media to understand public opinion offers up some hope and some concern. On the one hand, social media offers a way to

expand notions of public opinion, particularly in qualitative ways, while also giving marginalized voices easier access to elites. On the other hand, social media presents a more fractured sense of the public that is not comprehensive or representative, while also driving troubling shifts in the routines, practices, and output of journalists. Social media shrink and distort the nature of the polity, while also allowing journalists easy access to profiles and posts that fit their ‘imaginary portraits’ of the public (Herbst, 1998) and their ‘theory’ of a news story. At the same time, political opinions on social media – unlike those captured by surveys – are rooted in the cultural context of the sites themselves, the very platforms for our everyday sociality. In short, social media expand conceptions of public opinion but must be understood contextually in conjunction with other sources of public opinion data.

Acknowledgement

Thank you to Emily Van Duyn and David Valdini for assisting me in the coding process. I also wish to acknowledge all the journalists who took time out of the never-ending news cycle to speak with me about their work. This study stems from my dissertation, and I am so thankful to my chairs Dr. Gina Chen and Dr. Regina Lawrence and the rest of the committee, Dr. Thomas Johnson, Dr. Stephen Reese, and Dr. Talia Stroud, for their invaluable feedback that shaped this work. I presented an early version of this work at an ICA pre-conference organized by the guest editors, Dr. Stephen Cushion and Dr. Dan Jackson -- I thank them and the other attendees for their feedback on my work. I also thank anonymous reviewers whose suggestions improved this study.

Funding

The author(s) received no financial support for the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

Supplemental Material

Supplemental material for this article is available online.

Notes

1. Facebook describes Signal, their in-house tool, as ‘a free discovery and curation tool for journalists who want to source, gather, and embed newsworthy content from Facebook and Instagram, across news, culture, entertainment, sports, and more — all in one place’. <https://media.fb.com/2015/09/17/introducing-signal/>
2. Dataminr is a company whose algorithm filters Twitter data into alerts, and it is pitched as a way to identify breaking news. According to its website, Dataminr is used in over 350 newsrooms, including CNN, *The Telegraph*, AlJazeera, and Mashable.
3. <http://mediacloud.org/> and <https://mediacloud.org/election-2016>
4. <https://topics.mediacloud.org/#/topics/1404/summary?focusId&q&snapshotId=1628×panId=80252>
5. This study is one of several stemming from this data set. I chose particular sources so that, in another study, I could compare the use of social media as public opinion across outlet types, hypothesizing that, for example, digital-native outlets may engage in the practice proportionally more so than newspapers.
6. <https://assets.pewresearch.org/wp-content/uploads/sites/13/2016/06/30143308/state-of-the-news-media-report-2016-final.pdf>

7. Intercooder reliability was assessed using ReCal (Freelon, 2010, 2013).
8. https://www.washingtonpost.com/news/powerpost/wp/2015/12/16/the-daily-202-anger-won-and-rubio-lost-last-nights-debate/?utm_term=.6ff0d4826730
9. <http://www.msnbc.com/msnbc/ted-cruz-candy-crush-post-has-more-likes-rick-santorum-speech>
10. http://www.salon.com/2016/02/25/whichhillary_twitter_trend_calls_out_clinton_for_hypocrisy_on_racism_wall_street_and_war/
11. Third-person effect is when people perceive media messages have a greater impact on others than themselves (Antonopoulos et al., 2015).

References

- AAPOR (2013) The AAPOR task force on non-probability sampling. Available at: http://www.aapor.org/AAPOR_Main/media/MainSiteFiles/NPS_TF_Report_Final_7_revised_FNL_6_22_13.pdf
- Allport FH (1937) Toward a science of public opinion. *Public Opinion Quarterly* 1(1): 7–23.
- Anstead N and O’Loughlin B (2015) Social media analysis and public opinion: The 2010 UK general election. *Journal of Computer-Mediated Communication* 20(2): 204–220.
- Antonopoulos N, Veglis A, Gardikiotis A, et al. (2015) Web third-person effect in structural aspects of the information on media websites. *Computers in Human Behavior* 44: 48–58.
- Armstrong CL and Gao F (2010) Now tweet this: How news organizations use Twitter. *Electronic News* 4(4): 218–235.
- Bennett WL (1990) Toward a theory of press-state relations in the United States. *Journal of Communication* 40(2): 103–127.
- Berelson B (1952) Democratic theory and public opinion. *Public Opinion Quarterly* 16: 313–330.
- Blumer H (1948) Public opinion and public opinion polling. *American Sociological Review* 13(5): 542–549.
- Broersma M and Graham T (2016) Tipping the balance of power social media and the transformation of political journalism. In: Bruns A, Enli G, Skogerbo E, et al. (eds) *The Routledge Companion to Social Media and Politics*. London: Routledge, pp. 89–103.
- Chadwick A (2013) *The Hybrid Media System: Politics and Power*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Dunaway J (2011) Institutional effects on the information quality of campaign news. *Journalism Studies* 12(1): 27–44.
- Entman RM and Herbst S (2001) Reframing public opinion as we have known it. In: Bennett W (ed.) *Mediated Politics: Communication in the Future of Democracy*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, pp. 203–225.
- Fishkin JS (2006) Beyond polling alone: The quest for an informed public. *Critical Review* 18(1–3): 157–165.
- Freelon DG (2010) ReCal: Intercooder reliability calculation as a web service. *International Journal of Internet Science* 5(1): 20–33.
- Freelon D (2013) ReCal OIR: Ordinal, Interval, and Ratio Intercooder Reliability as a Web Service. *International Journal of Internet Science* 8(1): 10–16.
- Gallup G and Rae SF (1940) *The Pulse of Democracy: The Public-Opinion Poll and How it Works*. Oxford: Simon & Schuster
- Gil de Zúñiga H, García-Perdomo V and McGregor SC (2015) What is second screening? Exploring motivations of second screen use and its effect on online political participation. *Journal of Communication* 65(5): 793–815.

- Goidel K (2011) Public opinion polling in a digital age: Meaning and measurement. In: Goidel K (ed.) *Public Opinion Polling in a Digital Age: The Challenge of Measuring and Understanding Public Opinion*. Baton Rouge, LA: Louisiana State University Press, pp. 11–27.
- Graber DA (2006) Government by the people, for the people – twenty-first century style. *Critical Review* 18(1–3): 167–178.
- Habermas J (1989) *The Structural Transformation of the Public Sphere* (trans. T Burger). Cambridge, MA: The MIT Press.
- Herbst S (1993) *Numbered Voices: How Opinion Polling Has Shaped American Politics*. Chicago, IL: The University of Chicago Press.
- Herbst S (1998) *Reading Public Opinion: How Political Actors View the Democratic Process*. Chicago, IL: The University of Chicago Press.
- Igo SE (2007) *The Average American: Surveys, Citizens, and the Making of a Mass Public*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.
- Iyengar S, Norpoth H and Hahn KS (2004) Consumer demand for election news: The horserace sells. *The Journal of Politics* 66(1): 157–175.
- Jennings W and Wlezien C (2018) Election polling errors across time and space. *Nature Human Behaviour* 2: 276–283.
- Jungherr A (2015) *Analyzing Political Communication with Digital Trace Data*. Cham: Springer.
- Karpf D (2016) *Analytic Activism: Digital Listening and the New Political Strategy*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Kreiss D and McGregor SC (2017) Technology firms shape political communication: The work of Microsoft, Facebook, Twitter, and Google with campaigns during the 2016 US presidential cycle. *Political Communication* 35: 155–177.
- Lasorsa DL, Lewis SC and Holton AE (2012) Normalizing Twitter: Journalism practice in an emerging communication space. *Journalism Studies* 13(1): 19–36.
- Lavrakas PJ and Traugott MW (eds) (2000) *Election Polls, the News Media, and Democracy*. London: Chatham House.
- Lawrence RG (2000) Game-framing the issues: Tracking the strategy frame in public policy news. *Political Communication* 17(2): 93–114.
- Lawrence RG, Molyneux L, Coddington M, and Holton A (2014) Tweeting Conventions: Political journalists’ use of Twitter to cover the 2012 presidential campaign. *Journalism Studies* 15(6): 789–806.
- Luker K (2008) *Salsa Dancing into the Social Sciences*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.
- Lukito J and Wells C (2018) Most major outlets have used Russian tweets as sources for partisan opinion: Study. *Columbia Journalism Review*. Available at: <https://www.cjr.org/analysis/tweets-russia-news.php>
- McGregor SC and Molyneux L (2018) Twitter’s influence on news judgment: An experiment among journalists. *Journalism*. Epub ahead of print 5 October. DOI: 10.1177/1464884918802975.
- Mitchell A, Holcomb J and Weisel R (2016) Election 2016: Campaigns as a direct source of news. *Pew Research Center*. Available at: <https://www.journalism.org/2016/07/18/election-2016-campaigns-as-a-direct-source-of-news/>
- Molyneux L and Mourão RR (2017) Political journalists’ normalization of twitter: Interaction and new affordances. *Journalism Studies* 20: 248–266.
- Mourão RR (2015) The boys on the timeline: Political journalists’ use of Twitter for building interpretive communities. *Journalism* 16(8): 1107–1123.
- Peters JD (1995) Historical tensions in the concept of public opinion. In Glasser TL and Salmon CT (eds) *Public Opinion and the Communication of Consent*. New York: Guilford Press.

- Pew Research Center (2012) Assessing the representativeness of public opinion surveys. Available at: <http://www.people-press.org/2012/05/15/assessing-the-representativeness-of-public-opinion-surveys/>
- Pew Research Center (2016) Social media update 2016. Available at: <http://www.pewinternet.org/2016/11/11/social-media-update-2016/>
- Rosenstiel T (2005) Political polling and the new media culture: A case of more being less. *Public Opinion Quarterly* 69(5): 698–715.
- Schober MF, Pasek J, Guggenheim L, et al. (2016) Social media analyses for social measurement. *Public Opinion Quarterly* 80(1): 180–211.
- Shoemaker PJ and Reese SD (2013) *Mediating the Message in the 21st Century: A Media Sociology Perspective*. London: Routledge.
- Toff BJ (2016) *The Blind Scorekeepers: Journalism, Polling, and the Battle to Define Public Opinion in American Politics*. Doctoral dissertation, University of Wisconsin–Madison, Madison, WI.
- Vaccari C, Chadwick A and O’Loughlin B (2015) Dual screening the political: Media events, social media, and citizen engagement. *Journal of Communication* 65(6): 1041–1061.
- Zaller J (1992) *The Nature and Origins of Mass Opinion*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Zaller J (1998) The rule of product substitution in presidential campaign news. *The ANNALS of the American Academy of Political and Social Science* 560(1): 111–128.
- Zukin C (2015) What’s the matter with polling? *The New York Times*. Available at: <https://www.nytimes.com/2015/06/21/opinion/sunday/whats-the-matter-with-polling.html>

Author biography

Shannon C McGregor (PhD, University of Texas) is an Assistant Professor in the Department of Communication at The University of Utah. Her research interests are political communication, social media, gender, and public opinion.